

Rush, which was then in full swing. He formed the Minnehoma Oil Company and began prospecting for oil.

My father, a self-made man who had known extreme poverty in his youth, had a practically limitless capacity for hard work, and he also had an almost uncanny talent for finding oil. After organizing Minnehoma Oil, he personally supervised the drilling of 43 oil wells, of which 42 proved to be producers!

I served a tough and valuable apprenticeship working as a roustabout and tooldresser in the oil fields in 1910 and 1911, but I didn't go into the oil business for myself until September 1914. I had but recently returned to the United States after attending Oxford University in England for two years. My original intent was to enter the U.S.

Diplomatic Service, but I deferred that plan in order to try my luck as an independent operator—a wildcatter—in Oklahoma.

The times were favorable. It was a bonanza era for the burgeoning American petroleum industry. A lusty, brawling pioneer spirit still prevailed in the oil fields. The Great Oil Rush continued with unabated vigor and was given added impetus by the war that had broken out in Europe that year. Primitive boom towns dotted the Oklahoma countryside. Many bore bare-knuckled frontier-

### 3

era names such as those of the four "Right" towns: Drumright, Dropright, Allright and Damnright.

Streets and roads were unpaved—rivers of mushy clay and mud in spring and winter and sun-baked, rutted tracks perpetually shrouded by billowing clouds of harsh red or yellow dust in summer. Duckboard sidewalks outside the more prosperous business establishments and gambling halls were viewed as the ultimate in civic improvements.

The atmosphere was identical to that which historians describe as prevailing in the California gold fields during the 1849 Gold Rush. In Oklahoma, the